

Ara Vus Prec

by

T. S. Eliot

THE OVID PRESS

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*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK ARA VUS PREC

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T. S. Eliot



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*Or puoi, la quantitate
Comprender dell'amor ch'a te mi scalda,
Quando dismento nostra vanitate
Trattando l'ombre come cosa salda.*

CONTENTS

	<i>page</i>
<i>Gerontion</i>	<u>11</u>
<i>Burbank</i>	<u>14</u>
<i>Sweeny among the Nightingales</i>	<u>16</u>
<i>Sweeny erect</i>	<u>18</u>
<i>Mr. Eliot's Sunday Morning Service</i>	<u>20</u>
<i>Whispers of Immortality</i>	<u>21</u>
<i>The Hippopotamus</i>	<u>22</u>
<i>A Cooking Egg</i>	<u>24</u>
<i>Lune de Miel</i>	<u>26</u>
<i>Dans le Restaurant</i>	<u>27</u>
<i>Le Spectateur</i>	<u>28</u>
<i>Mélange Adultère de Tout</i>	<u>29</u>
<i>Ode</i>	<u>30</u>
<i>Prufrock</i>	<u>33</u>
<i>Portrait of a Lady</i>	<u>38</u>
<i>Preludes</i>	<u>43</u>
<i>Rhapsody of a Windy Night</i>	<u>45</u>
<i>Morning at the Window</i>	<u>48</u>
<i>Conversation Galante</i>	<u>49</u>
<i>Aunt Helen</i>	<u>50</u>
<i>Cousin Nancy</i>	<u>51</u>
<i>Mr. Apollinax</i>	<u>52</u>
<i>The Boston Evening Transcript</i>	<u>53</u>
<i>La Figlia Che Piange</i>	<u>54</u>

THIS IS NO.

GERONTION

*Thou hast nor youth nor age
But as it were, an after dinner sleep
Dreaming of both.*



ERE I am, an old
man in a dry
month
Being read to by
a boy, waiting
for rain.
I was neither at
the hot gates
Nor fought in the
warm rain
Nor knee deep in
the salt marsh,
heaving a
cutlass,
Bitten by flies,
fought.
My house is a
decayed house

And the jew squats on the window sill, the owner,
Spawned in some estaminet of Antwerp,
Blistered in Brussels, patched and peeled in London.
The goat coughs at night in the field overhead;
Rocks, moss, stonecrop, iron, merds.
The woman keeps the kitchen, makes tea,
Sneezes at evening, poking the peevish gutter.

I an old man,
A dull head among windy spaces.

Signs are taken for wonders. "We would see a sign."
The word within a word, unable to speak a word,
Swaddled with darkness. In the juvenescence of the year
Came Christ the tiger
In depraved May, dogwood and chestnut, flowering judas,
To be eaten, to be divided, to be drunk
Among whispers; by Mr. Silvero
With caressing hands, at Limoges

Who walked all night in the next room;
By Hakagama, bowing among the Titians;
By Madame de Tornquist, in the dark room
Shifting the candles; Fraülein von Kulp
Who turned in the hall, one hand on the door. Vacant shuttles
Weave the wind. I have no ghosts,
An old man in a draughty house
Under a windy knob.

After such knowledge, what forgiveness? Think now
History has many cunning passages, contrived corridors
And issues; deceives with whispering ambitions,
Guides us by vanities. Think now
She gives when our attention is distracted,
And what she gives, gives with such supple confusions
That the giving famishes the craving. Gives too late
What's not believed in, or if still believed,
In memory only, reconsidered passion. Gives too soon
Into weak hands what's thought can be dispensed with
Till the refusal propagates a fear. Think
Neither fear nor courage saves us. Unnatural vices
Are fathered by our heroism. Virtues
Are forced upon us by our impudent crimes.

These tears are shaken from the wrath-bearing tree.

The tiger springs in the new year. Us he devours. Think at last
We have not reached conclusion, when I
Stiffen in a rented house. Think at last

I have not made this show purposelessly
And it is not by any concitation
Of the backward devils.
I would meet you upon this honestly.
I that was near your heart was removed therefrom
To lose beauty in terror, terror in inquisition.
I have lost my passion: why should I want to keep it
Since what is kept must be adulterated?
I have lost my sight, smell, hearing, taste and touch:
How should I use it for your closer contact?

These with a thousand small deliberations
Protract the profit of their chilled delirium,
Excite the membrane, when the sense has cooled,
With pungent sauces, multiply variety
In a wilderness of mirrors. What will the spider do,
Suspend its operations, will the weevil
Delay? De Bailhache, Fresca, Mrs Cammell, whirled
Beyond the circuit of the shuddering Bear
In fractured atoms. Gull against the wind, in the windy straits
Of Belle Isle, or running by the Horn,
White feathers in the snow, the gulf claims
And an old man, driven on the Trades
To a sleepy corner.

Tenants of the house,
Thoughts of a dry brain in a dry season.

BURBANK WITH A BAEDEKER: BLEISTEIN WITH A CIGAR.

*Tra la la la la laire—nil nisi divinum stabile est;
cætera fumus—the gondola stopped the old palace
was there How charming it's grey & pink—Goats &
monkeys, with such hair too!—so the Countess
passed on until she came through the little park,
where Niobe presented her with a cabinet, & so
departed.*



URBANK crossed a
little bridge
Descending at a
small hotel;
Princess
Volupine arrived,
They were
together, and he
fell.

Defunctive
music under sea
Passed
seaward with the
passing bell
Slowly: the god
Hercules
Had left him,

that had loved him well.

The horses, under the axletree
Beat up the dawn from Istria
With even feet. Her shuttered barge

Burned on the water all the day.

But this or such was Bleistein's way:
A saggy bending of the knees
And elbows, with the palms turned out,
Chicago Semite Viennese.

A lustreless protrusive eye
Stares from the protozoic slime
At a perspective of Canaletto.
The smoky candle end of time

Declines. On the Rialto once.
The rats are underneath the piles.
The jew is underneath the lot.
Money in furs. The boatman smiles,

Princess Volupine extends
A meagre, blue-nailed, phthisic hand
To climb the waterstair. Lights, lights,
She entertains Sir Ferdinand

Klein. Who clipped the lion's wings
And flea'd his rump and pared his claws?
—Thought Burbank, meditating on
Time's ruins, and the seven laws.

SWEENEY AMONG THE NIGHTINGALES

ὦμοι, πέπληγμαι καιρίαν πγελὴν ἔσω

WHY SHOULD I SPEAK OF THE NIGHTINGALE?

THE NIGHTINGALE SINGS OF ADULTEROUS WRONG.



PENECK Sweeney
spreads his knees
Letting his arms
hang down to
laugh,
The zebra stripes
along his jaw
Swelling to
maculate giraffe.

The circles of the
stormy moon
Slide
westward to the
River Plate,
Death and the
Raven drift
above

And Sweeney guards the horned gate.

Gloomy Orion and the Dog
Are veiled; and hushed the shrunken seas;
The person in the Spanish cape
Tries to sit on Sweeney's knees

Slips and pulls the table cloth

Overturns a coffee cup,
Reorganised upon the floor
She yawns and draws a stocking up;

The silent man in mocha brown
Sprawls at the window sill and gapes;
The waiter brings in oranges,
Bananas, figs and hot-house grapes;

The silent vertebrate exhales,
Contracts and concentrates, withdraws;
Rachel née Rabinovitch
Tears at the grapes with murderous paws;

She and the lady in the cape
Are suspect, thought to be in league;
Therefore the man with heavy eyes
Declines the gambit, shows fatigue,

Leaves the room and reappears
Outside the window, leaning in,
Branches of wistaria
Circumscribe a golden grin;

The host with someone indistinct
Converses at the door apart,
The nightingales are singing near
The convent of the Sacred Heart,

And sang within the bloody wood
When Agamemnon cried aloud
And let their liquid siftings fall
To stain the stiff dishonoured shroud.

SWEENEY ERECT

*And the trees about me
Let them be dry & leafless; let the rocks
Groan with continual surges; & behind me
Make all a desolation. Look, Look, wenches!*



PAINT me a
cavernous waste
shore
Cast in the
unstilled
Cyclades,
Paint me the bold
anfractuous
rocks

Faced by the
snarled and
yelping seas.

Display me
Æolus above
Reviewing the
insurgent gales
Which tangle

Ariadne's hair
And swell with haste the perjured sails.

Morning stirs the feet and hands
(Nausicaa and Polypheme);
Gesture of orang-outang
Rises from the sheets in steam.

This withered root of knots of hair
 Slitted below and gashed with eyes,
This oval O cropped out with teeth;
 The sickle motion from the thighs

Jackknifes upward at the knees
 Then straightens down from heel to hip
Pushing the framework of the bed
 And clawing at the pillow slip.

Sweeney addressed full-length to shave
 Broadbottomed, pink from nape to base,
Knows the female temperament
 And wipes the suds around his face.

(The lengthened shadow of a man
 Is history, says Emerson,
Who had not seen the silhouette
 Of Sweeney straddled in the sun).

Tests the razor on his leg
 Waiting until the shriek subsides;
The epileptic on the bed
 Curves backward, clutching at her sides.

The ladies of the corridor
 Find themselves involved, disgraced;
Call witness to their principles
 Deprecate the lack of taste

Observing that hysteria
 Might easily be misunderstood;
Mrs. Turner intimates
 It does the house no sort of good.

But Doris towelled from the bath
 Enters padding on broad feet,
Bringing sal volatile

And a glass of brandy neat.

MR. ELIOT'S SUNDAY MORNING SERVICE

*“Look, look master, here comes two of the religious
caterpillars”.*

JEW OF MALTA



OLYPHILOPROGENITI
VE

The sapient
sutlers of the
Lord
Drift across the
window-panes.

In the
beginning was
the Word.

In the beginning
was the Word,
Superfetation
of το εν
And at the
mensual turn of
time

Produced enervate Origen.

A painter of the Umbrian school
Designed upon a gesso ground
The nimbus of the Baptised God.
The wilderness is cracked and browned

But through the water pale and thin

Still shine the unoffending feet
And there above the painter set
The father and the Paraclete.

The sable presbyters approach
The avenue of penitence;
The young are red and pustular
Clutching piaculative pence,

Under the penitential gates
Sustained by staring Seraphim
Where the souls of the devout
Burn invisible and dim.

Along the garden-wall the bees
With hairy bellies pass between
The staminate and pistilate:
Blest office of the epicene.

Sweeney shifts from ham to ham
Stirring the water in his bath.
The masters of the subtle schools
Are controversial, polymath.

WHISPERS OF IMMORTALITY



EBSTER was much
possessed by
death
And saw the
skull beneath the
skin;
And breastless
creatures under
ground

 Leaned
backward with a
lipless grin.

Daffodil bulbs
instead of balls

 Stared from
the sockets of the
eyes!

He knew that thought clings round dead limbs
 Tightening its lusts and luxuries.

Donne, I suppose, was such another
 Who found no substitute for sense
To seize and clutch and penetrate,
 Expert beyond experience

He knew the anguish of the marrow
 The ague of the skeleton;
No contact possible to flesh
 Allayed the fever of the bone.

Grishkin is nice; her Russian eye

Is underlined for emphasis;
Uncorseted, her friendly bust
Gives promise of pneumatic bliss.

The couched Brazilian jaguar
Compels the scampering marmoset
With subtle effluence of cat;
Grishkin has a maisonette:

The sleek and sinuous jaguar
Does not in his arboreal gloom
Distil so rank a feline smell
As Grishkin in a drawing-room.

And even abstracter entities
Circumambulate her charm;
But our lot crawls between dry ribs
To keep its metaphysics warm.

THE HIPPOPOTAMUS

Similiter et omnes reveantur Diaconos, ut mandatum Jesu Christi; et Episcopum, ut Jesum Christum, existentem filium Patris; Presbyteros autem, ut concilium Dei et Conjunctionem Apostolorum. Sine his Ecclesia non vocatur; de quibus suadeo vos sic habeo.

S. IGNATII AD TRALLIANOS.

And when this epistle is read among you, cause that it be read also in the church of the Laodiceans.



HE broad backed
hippopotamus
Rests on his
belly on the mud;
Although he
seems so firm to
us

He is merely
flesh and blood.

Flesh-and-blood
is weak and frail,

Susceptible to
nervous shock;
While the True
Church can
never fail

For it is based

upon a rock.

The hippo's feeble steps may err

In compassing material ends,
While the True Church need never stir
To gather in its dividends.

The potamus can never reach
The mango on the mango tree;
But fruits of pomegranate and peach
Refresh the Church from over sea.

At mating time the hippo's voice
Betrays inflexions hoarse and odd,
But every week we hear rejoice
The Church, at being one with God.

The hippopotamus's day
Is past in sleep; at night he hunts;
God works in a mysterious way
The Church can sleep and eat at once.

I saw the potamus take wing
Ascending from the damp savannas,
And quiring angels round him sing
The praise of God in loud hosannas.

Blood of the Lamb shall wash him clean
And him shall heavenly arms enfold,
Among the saints he shall be seen
Performing on a harp of gold.

He shall be washed as white as snow,
By all the martyr'd virgins kist,
While the True Church remains below
Wrapt in the old miasmal mist.

A COOKING EGG

*En l'an trentiesme de mon aage
Que toutes mes hontes j'ay beues...*



An Invitation to the Dance.

IPIT sate upright in
her chair
Some distance
from where I was
sitting;
*Views of the
Oxford Colleges*
Lay on the
table with the
knitting.

Daguerrotypes
and silhouettes,
Her
grandfather and
great great aunts,
Supported on the
mantelpiece

I shall not want Honour in Heaven
For I shall meet Sir Philip Sidney
And have talk with Coriolanus
And other heroes of that kidney.

I shall not want Capital in Heaven
For I shall meet Sir Alfred Mond:
We two shall lie together, lapt
In a five per cent Exchequer Bond.

I shall not want Society in Heaven
 Lucretia Borgia shall be my Bride;
Her anecdotes will be more amusing
 Than Pipit's experience could provide.

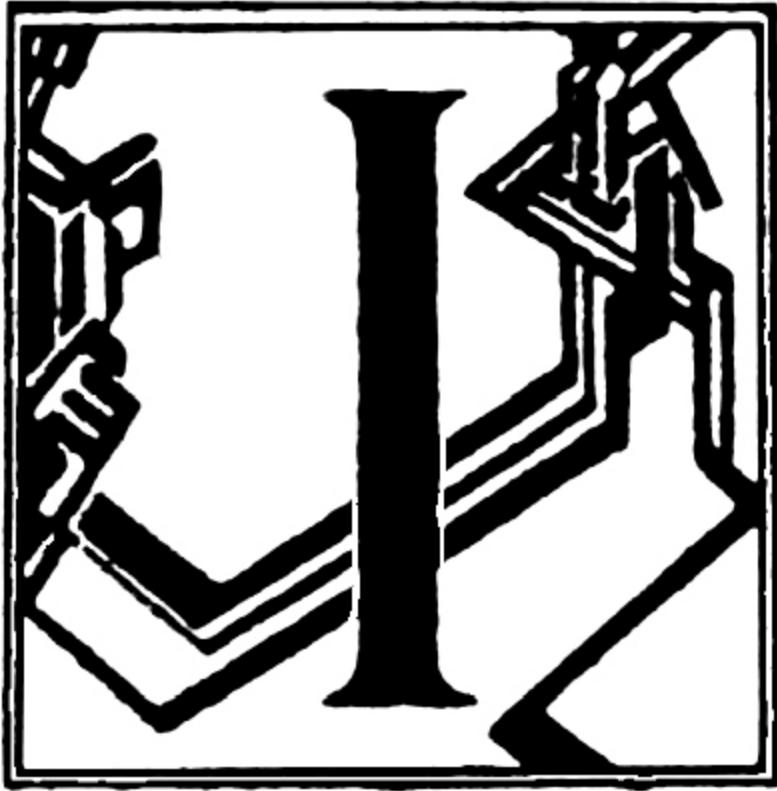
I shall not want Pipit in Heaven:
 Madame Blavatsky will instruct me
In the seven Sacred Trances;
 Piccarda de' Donati will conduct me....

But where is the penny world I bought
 To eat with Pipit behind the screen?
The red-eyed scavengers are creeping
 From Kentish Town and Golder's Green;

Where are the eagles and the trumpets?

Buried beneath some snow-deep Alps.
 Over buttered scones and crumpets
Weeping, weeping multitudes
 Droop in a hundred A. B. C.'s.

LUNE DE MIEL



LS ont vu les
Pays-Bas, ils
rentrent à Terre
Haute;
Mais une nuit
d'été, les voici à
Ravenne,
A l'aise entre
deux draps, chez
deux centaines
de punaises;
La sueur estivale,
et une forte
odeur de
chienne.
Ils restent sur le
dos écartant les
genoux

De quatre jambes molles tout gonflées de morsures.
On relève le drap pour mieux égratigner.
Moins d'une lieue d'ici est Sainte Apollinaire
In Classe, basilique connue des amateurs
De chapiteaux d'acanthé que tournoie le vent.

Ils vont prendre le train de huit heures
Prolonger leurs misères de Padoue à Milan
Où se trouvent le Cène, et un restaurant pas cher.
Lui pense aux pourboires, et rédige son bilan.
Ils auront vu la Suisse et traversé la France,
Et Sainte Apollinaire, raide et ascétique,
Vieille usine désaffectée de Dieu, tient encore
Dans ses pierres écroulantes la forme précise de Byzance.

DANS LE RESTAURANT



E garçon délabré
qui n'a rien à
faire
Que de se gratter
les doigts et se
pencher sur mon
épaule:
"Dans mon pays,
il fera temps
pluvieux,
Du vent, du
grand soleil et de
la pluie;
C'est ce qu'on
appelle le jour de
lessive des
gueux."
(Bavard, baveux,

à la croupe arrondie,
Je t'en prie, au moins, ne bave pas dans la soupe.)
"Les saules tout trempés, et des bourgeons sur les ronces—
C'est là, dans une averse, qu'on s'abrite.
J'avais sept ans, elle était plus petite.
Elle était toute mouillée, je lui ai donné des primevères."
Les tâches de son gilet montent au chiffre de trente-huit.
"Je la chatouillais, pour la faire rire.
Elle avait une odeur fraîche qui m'était inconnue,—"

Mais alors, vieux lubrique—

"Monsieur, le fait est dur,
Il est venu, nous péloter, un gros chien,
Moi j'avais peur, je l'ai quittée à mi-chemin;

C'est dommage."

Mais alors, tu as ton vautour.

Va-t'en te décrotter les rides du visage;
Tiens, ma fourchette, dégrasse-toi le crâne,
De quel droit paies-tu des expériences comme moi?
Tiens, voilà dix sous, pour la salle-de-bain.

Phlébas, le Phénicien, pendant quinze jours noyé,
Oubliait le cri des mouettes et la houle de Cornouaille,
Et les profits et les pertes, et la cargaison d'étain;
Un courant de sous-mer l'emporta très loin,
Le repassant aux étapes de sa vie antérieure.
Figurez-vous donc, c'était un sort pénible.
Cependant, ce fut jadis un bel homme, de haute taille.

LE SPECTATEUR



Dans un égout
Une petite fille
En guenilles
Camarde
Regarde
Le directeur
Du Spectateur
Conservateur
Et crève d'amour.

ALHEUR à
malheureuse
Tamise!
Qui coule si pres
du Spectateur.
Le directeur
Du Spectateur
Empeste la
brise.
Les
actionnaires
Réactionnaires
Du Spectateur
Conservateur
Bras-dessus
bras-dessous
Font des tours
A pas de loup.

MÉLANGE ADULTÈRE DE TOUT



N Amérique,
professeur;
En Angleterre,
journaliste;
C'est à grands
pas et en sueur
Que vous
suivrez à peine
ma piste.

En Yorkshire,
conférencier;

A Londres, un
peu banquier;

(Vous me
paierez bien la
tête.)

C'est à Paris
que je me coiffe

Casque noir de jemenfoutiste.
En Allemagne, philosophe
Surexcité par Emporheben
Au grand air de Bergsteigleben;
J'erre toujours de-ci de-là
A divers coups de tra la la
De Damas jusque à Omaha;
Je célébrai mon jour de fête
Dans un oasis d'Afrique,
Vêtu d'une peau de girafe.

On montrera mon cénotaphe
Aux côtes brulantes de Mozambique.

ODE

*To you particularly, and to all the Volscians
Great hurt and mischief.*



URED.

Subterrene
laughter
synchronous
With silence
from the sacred
wood
And bubbling of
the uninspired
Mephitic river.

Misunderstood

The accents of the now retired
Profession of the calamus.

Tortured.

When the bridegroom smoothed his hair
There was blood upon the bed.
Morning was already late.
Children singing in the orchard
(Io Hymen, Hymenæe)

Succuba eviscerate.

Tortuous.

By arrangement with Perseus

The fooled resentment of the dragon

Sailing before the wind at dawn.

Golden apocalypse. Indignant

At the cheap extinction of his taking-off.

Now lies he there

Tip to tip washed beneath Charles' Wagon.

PRUFROCK.

THE LOVE SONG OF J. ALFRED PRUFROCK

*S'io credesse che mia risposta fosse
A persona che mai tornasse al mondo,
Questa fiamma staria senza più scosse.
Ma perciocche giammai di questo fondo
Non torno vivo alcun, s'i' odo il vero,
Senza tema d'infamia ti rispondo.*



cheap hotels
And sawdust restaurants with oyster-shells:
Streets that follow like a tedious argument
Of insidious intent

US GO THEN, YOU
AND I,
When the
evening is spread
out against the
sky
Like a patient
etherized upon a
table;
Let us go,
through certain
half-deserted
streets,
The muttering
retreats

Of restless nights
in one-night

To lead you to an overwhelming question....
Oh, do not ask, "What is it?"
Let us go and make our visit.

In the room the women come and go
Talking of Michelangelo.

The yellow fog that rubs its back upon the window-panes,
The yellow smoke that rubs its muzzle on the window-panes,
Licked its tongue into the corners of the evening,
Lingered upon the pools that stand in drains,
Let fall upon its back the soot that falls from chimneys,
Slipped by the terrace, made a sudden leap,
And seeing that it was a soft October night,
Curled once about the house, and fell asleep.

And indeed there will be time
For the yellow smoke that slides along the street,
Rubbing its back upon the window-panes;
There will be time, there will be time
To prepare a face to meet the faces that you meet;
There will be time to murder and create,
And time for all the works and days of hands
That lift and drop a question on your plate;
Time for you and time for me,
And time yet for a hundred indecisions,
And for a hundred visions and revisions,
Before the taking of a toast and tea.

In the room the women come and go
Talking of Michelangelo.

And indeed there will be time
To wonder, "Do I dare?" and, "Do I dare?"
Time to turn back and descend the stair,
With a bald spot in the middle of my hair—
(They will say: "How his hair is growing thin!")
My morning coat, my collar mounting firmly to the chin,

My necktie rich and modest, but asserted by a simple pin—
(They will say: “But how his arms and legs are thin!”)
Do I dare
Disturb the universe?
In a minute there is time
For decisions and revisions which a minute will reverse.

For I have known them all already, known them all:
Have known the evenings, mornings, afternoons,
I have measured out my life with coffee spoons;
I know the voices dying with a dying fall
Beneath the music from a farther room.
So how should I presume?

And I have known the eyes already, known them all—
The eyes that fix you in a formulated phrase,
And when I am formulated, sprawling on a pin,
When I am pinned and wriggling on the wall,
Then how should I begin
To spit out all the butt-ends of my ways and days?
And how should I presume?

And I have known the arms already, known them all—
Arms that are braceleted and white and bare
(But in the lamplight, downed with light brown hair!)
Is it perfume from a dress
That makes me so digress?
Arms that lie along a table, or wrap about a shawl.
And should I then presume?
And how should I begin?

Shall I say, I have gone at dusk through narrow streets
And watched the smoke that rises from the pipes
Of lonely men in shirtsleeves, leaning out of windows?...

I should have been a pair of ragged claws
Scuttling across the floors of silent seas.

And the afternoon, the evening, sleeps so peacefully!
Smoothed by long fingers,
Asleep ... tired ... or it malingers,
Stretched on the floor, here beside you and me.
Should I, after tea and cakes and ices,
Have the strength to force the moment to its crisis?
But though I have wept and fasted, wept and prayed,
Though I have seen my head (grown slightly bald) brought
 in upon a platter,
I am no prophet—and here's no great matter;
I have seen the moment of my greatness flicker,
And I have seen the eternal Footman hold my coat, and snicker,
And in short, I was afraid.

And would it have been worth it, after all,
After the cups, the marmalade, the tea,
Among the porcelain, among some talk of you and me,
Would it have been worth while,
To have bitten off the matter with a smile,
To have squeezed the universe into a ball
To roll it toward some overwhelming question,
To say: "I am Lazarus, come from the dead,
Come back to tell you all, I shall tell you all"—
If one, settling a pillow by her head,
 Should say: "That is not what I meant at all,
 That is not it, at all."

And would it have been worth it, after all,
Would it have been worth while,
After the sunsets and the dooryards and the sprinkled streets,
After the novels, after the teacups, after the skirts that trail
along the floor—
And this, and so much more?—
It is impossible to say just what I mean!
But as if a magic lantern threw the nerves in patterns on a screen:
Would it have been worth while

If one, settling a pillow or throwing off a shawl,
And turning toward the window, should say:

“That is not it at all,
That is not what I meant, at all.”

No! I am not Prince Hamlet, nor was meant to be;
Am an attendant, lord, one that will do
To swell a progress, start a scene or two,
Advise the prince; no doubt, an easy tool,
Deferential, glad to be of use,
Politic, cautious, and meticulous;
Full of high sentence, but a bit obtuse;
At times, indeed, almost ridiculous—
Almost, at times, the Fool.

I grow old ... I grow old ...
I shall wear the bottom of my trousers rolled.

Shall I part my hair behind? Do I dare to eat a peach?
I shall wear white flannel trousers, and walk upon the beach.
I have heard the mermaids singing, each to each.

I do not think that they will sing to me.

I have seen them riding seaward on the waves
Combing the white hair of the waves blown back
When the wind blows the water white and black.

We have lingered in the chambers of the sea
By sea-girls wreathed with seaweed red and brown
Till human voices wake us, and we drown.

PORTRAIT OF A LADY

*Thou hast committed—
Fornication: but that was in another country,
And besides, the wench is dead.*

THE JEW OF MALTA

I



AMONG the smoke
and fog of a
December
afternoon
You have the
scene arrange
itself—as it will
seem to do—
With “I have
saved this
afternoon for
you”;
And four wax
candles in the
darkened room,
Four rings of
light upon the
ceiling overhead,

An atmosphere of Juliet’s tomb
Prepared for all the things to be said, or left unsaid.
We have been, let us say, to hear the latest Pole
Transmit the Preludes, through his hair and finger-tips.
“So intimate, this Chopin, that I think his soul
Should be resurrected only among friends
Some two or three, who will not touch the bloom
That is rubbed and questioned in the concert room.”

—And so the conversation slips
Among velleities and carefully caught regrets
Through attenuated tones of violins
Mingled with remote cornets
And begins.

“You do not know how much they mean to me, my friends,
And how, how rare and strange it is, to find
In a life composed so much, so much of odds and ends,
(For indeed I do not love it ... you knew? you are not blind!
How keen you are!)
To find a friend who has these qualities,
Who has, and gives
Those qualities upon which friendship lives.
How much it means that I say this to you—
Without these friendships—life, what *cauchemar*!”
Among the windings of the violins
And the ariettes
Of cracked cornets
Inside my brain a dull tom-tom begins
Absurdly hammering a prelude of its own,
Capricious monotone
That is at least one definite “false note”.
—Let us take the air, in a tobacco trance,
Admire the monuments
Discuss the late events,
Correct our watches by the public clocks.
Then sit for half an hour and drink our bocks.

II

Now that lilacs are in bloom
She has a bowl of lilacs in her room
And twists them in her fingers while she talks.
“Ah, my friend, you do not know, you do not know
What life is, you who hold it in your hands;”
(Slowly twisting the lilac stalks)

“You let it flow from you, you let it flow
And youth is cruel, and has no remorse
And smiles at situations which it cannot see.”
I smile, of course,
And go on drinking tea.

“Yet with these April sunsets, that somehow recall
My buried life, and Paris in the Spring,
I feel immeasurably at peace, and find the world
To be wonderful and youthful, after all.”

The voice returns like the insistent out-of-tune
Of a broken violin on an August afternoon:
“I am always sure that you understand
My feelings, always sure that you feel,
Sure that across the gulf you reach your hand.

You are invulnerable, you have no Achilles’ heel.
You will go on, and when you have prevailed
You can say: at this point many a one has failed.

But what have I, but what have I, my friend,
To give you, what can you receive from me?
Only the friendship and the sympathy
Of one about to reach her journey’s end.

I shall sit here, serving tea to friends....”

I take my hat: how can I make a cowardly amends
For what she has said to me?

You will see me any morning in the park
Reading the comics and the sporting page.
Particularly I remark
An English countess goes upon the stage.
A Greek was murdered at a Polish dance,
Another bank defaulter has confessed.
I keep my countenance,

I remain self-possessed
Except when a street piano, mechanical and tired
Reiterates some worn-out common song
With the smell of hyacinths across the garden
Recalling things that other people have desired.
Are these ideas right or wrong?

III

The October night comes down; returning as before
Except for a slight sensation of being ill at ease
I mount the stairs and turn the handle of the door
And feel as if I had mounted on my hands and knees.

“And so you are going abroad; and when do you return?
But that’s a useless question.
You hardly know when you are coming back,
You will find so much to learn.”
My smile falls heavily among the bric-à-brac.

“Perhaps you can write to me.”
My self-possession flares up for a second;
This is as I had reckoned.
“I have been wondering frequently of late
(But our beginnings never know our ends!)
Why we have not developed into friends.”

I feel like one who smiles, and turning shall remark
Suddenly, his expression in a glass.
My self-possession gutters; we are really in the dark.

“For everybody said so, all our friends,
They all were sure our feelings would relate
So closely! I myself can hardly understand.
We must leave it now to fate.
You will write, at any rate.
Perhaps it is not too late.

I shall sit here, serving tea to friends.”

And I must borrow every changing shape
To find expression ... dance, dance
Like a dancing bear,
Cry like a parrot, chatter like an ape.
Let us take the air, in a tobacco trance—

Well! and what if she should die some afternoon,
Afternoon grey and smoky, evening yellow and rose;
Should die and leave me sitting pen in hand
With the smoke coming down above the house-tops;
Doubtful, for quite a while
Not knowing what to feel or if I understand
Or whether wise or foolish, tardy or too soon ...
Would she not have the advantage, after all?
This music is successful with a “dying fall”
Now that we talk of dying—
And should I have the right to smile?

PRELUDES

I



On broken blinds and chimney-pots,
And at the corner of the street
A lonely cab-horse steams and stamps.
And then the lighting of the lamps.

II

The morning comes to consciousness
Of faint stale smells of beer
From the sawdust-trampled street
With all its muddy feet that press
To early coffee-stands.

HE winter evening
settles down
With smell of
steaks in
passageways.
Six o'clock.
The burn-out
ends of smoky
days.
And now a gusty
shower wraps
The grimy scraps
Of withered
leaves about
your feet
And newspapers
from vacant lots;
The showers beat

With the other masquerades
That time resumes,

One thinks of all the hands
That are raising dingy shades
In a thousand furnished rooms.

III

You tossed a blanket from the bed,
You lay upon your back, and waited;
You dozed, and watched the night revealing
The thousand sordid images
Of which your soul was constituted;
They flickered against the ceiling.
And when all the world came back
And the light crept up between the shutters,
And you heard the sparrows in the gutters,
You had such a vision of the street
As the street hardly understands;
Sitting along the bed's edge, where
You curled the papers from your hair,
Or clasped the yellow soles of feet
In the palms of both soiled hands.

IV

His soul stretched tight across the skies
That fade behind a city block,
Or trampled by insistent feet
At four and five and six o'clock;
And short square fingers stuffing pipes,
And evening newspapers, and eyes
Assured of certain certainties,
The conscience of a blackened street
Impatient to assume the world.

I am moved by fancies that are curled

Around these images, and cling:
The notion of some infinitely gentle
Infinitely suffering thing.

Wipe your hand across your mouth, and laugh;
The worlds revolve like ancient women
Gathering fuel in vacant lots.

RHAPSODY ON A WINDY NIGHT



wELVE o'clock.
Along the
reaches of the
street
Held in a lunar
synthesis
Whispering lunar
incantations
Dissolve the
floors of the
memory
And all its clear
relations,
Its divisions and
precisions,
Every street
lamp that I pass
Beats like a

fatalistic drum,
And through the spaces of the dark
Midnight shakes the memory
As a madman shakes a dead geranium.

Half-past one.
The street lamp sputtered,
The street lamp muttered,
The street lamp said, "Regard that woman
Who hesitates toward you in the light of the door
Which opens on her like a grin.
You see the border of her dress
Is torn and stained with sand,

And you see the corner of her eye
Twists like a crooked pin.”

The memory throws up high and dry
A crowd of twisted things;
A twisted branch upon the beach
Eaten smooth and polished
As if the world gave up
The secret of its skeleton,
A broken spring in a factory yard,
Rust that clings to the form that the strength has left
Hard and curled and ready to snap.

Half-past two,
The street lamp said,
“Remark the cat which flattens itself in the gutter,
Slips out its tongue
And devours a morsel of rancid butter.”
So the hand of a child, automatic,
Slipped out and pocketed a toy that was running along the quay.
I could see nothing behind that child’s eye.
I have seen eyes in the street
Trying to peer through lighted shutters,
And a crab one afternoon in a pool,
An old crab with barnacles on his back,
Gripped the end of a stick which I held him.

Half-past three,
The lamp sputtered,
The lamp muttered in the dark.
The lamp hummed:
“Regard the moon,
La lune ne garde aucune rancune,
She winks a feeble eye,
She smiles into corners.
She smoothes the hair of the grass.
The moon has lost her memory.

A washed-out smallpox cracks her face,
Her hand twists a paper rose,
That smells of dust and old Cologne,
She is alone
With all the old nocturnal smells
That cross and cross across her brain.
The reminiscence comes
Of sunless dry geraniums
And dust in crevices,
Smells of chestnuts in the streets,
And female smells in shuttered rooms,
And cigarettes in corridors
And cocktail smells in bars.”

The lamp said
“Four o’clock,
Here is the number on the door.
Memory!
You have the key
The little lamp spreads a ring on the stair,
Mount.
The bed is open: the tooth-brush hangs on the wall,
Put your shoes at the door, sleep, prepare for life.”

The last twist of the knife.

MORNING AT THE WINDOW

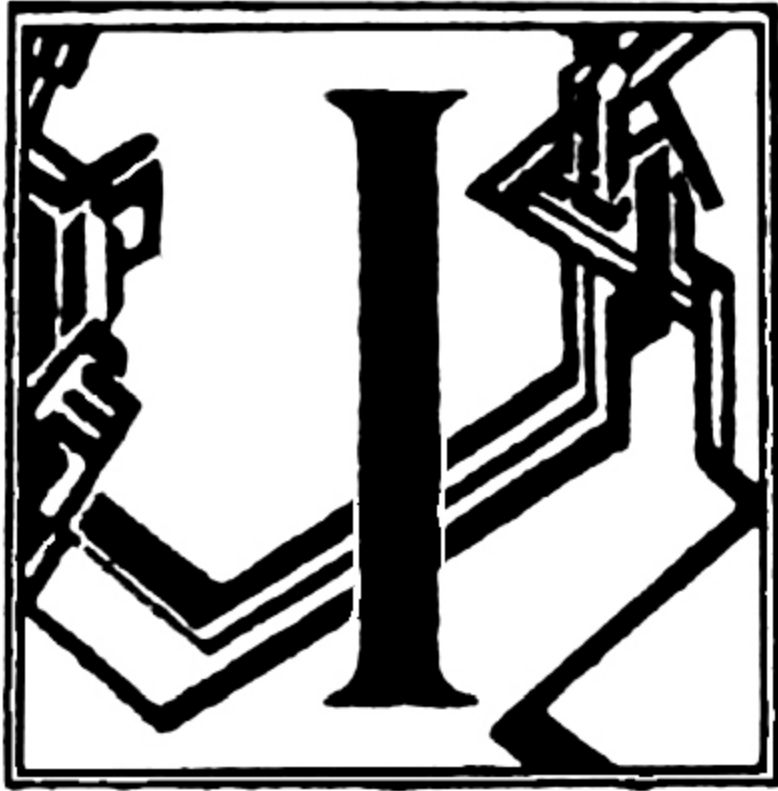


HEY are rattling
breakfast plates
in basement
kitchens
And along the
trampled edges
of the street
I am aware of the
damp souls of
housemaids
 Sprouting
despondently at
area gates.

 The brown
waves of fog toss
up to me
 Twisted faces

from the bottom of the street,
 And tear from a passer-by with muddy skirts
 An aimless smile that hovers in the air
 And vanishes along the level of the roofs.

CONVERSATION GALANTE



OBSERVE: "Our sentimental friend the moon! Or possibly (fantastic, I confess) It may be Prester John's balloon Or an old battered lantern hung aloft To light poor travellers to their distress."

She then: "How you digress!"

And I then: "Some one frames upon the keys That exquisite nocturne, with which we explain The night and moonshine; music which we seize To body forth our own vacuity."

She then: "Does this refer to me?"

"Oh no, it is I who am inane."

"You, madam, are the eternal humorist,
The eternal enemy of the absolute,
Giving our vagrant moods the slightest twist!
With your air indifferent and imperious
At a stroke our mad poetics to confute—"

And—"Are we then so serious?"

AUNT HELEN



MISS HELEN

SLINGSBY was my
maiden aunt,
Miss Helen
Slingsby was my
maiden aunt,
And lived in a
small house near
a fashionable
square

Cared for by
servants to the
number of four.

Now when she
died there was
silence in heaven

And silence at
her end of the

street.

The shutters were drawn and the undertaker wiped his feet—
He was aware that this sort of thing had occurred before.
The dogs were handsomely provided for,
But shortly afterwards the parrot died too.
The Dresden clock continued ticking on the mantelpiece,
And the footman sat upon the dining-table
Holding the second house-maid on his knees—
Who had always been so careful while her mistress lived.

COUSIN NANCY



MISS NANCY
ELLICOTT
Strode across the
hills and broke
them,
Rode across the
hills and broke
them—
The barren New
England hills—
Riding to hounds
Over the cow-
pasture.

Miss Nancy
Ellicott smoked
And danced all
the modern

dances;
And her aunts were not quite sure how they felt about it,
But they knew that it was modern.

Upon the glazen shelves kept watch
Matthew and Waldo, guardians of the faith,
The army of unalterable law.

MR. APOLLINAX

Ω τῆς καινότητος. Ἡράκλεις, τῆς παραδοξογίας. εὐμήχανος
ἄνθρωπος.



HEN Mr.
Apollinax visited
the United States
His laughter
tinkled among
the teacups.
I thought of
Fragilion, that
shy figure among
the birch-trees,
And of Priapus
in the shrubbery
Gaping at the
lady in the
swing.
In the palace of
Mrs. Phlaccus, at
Professor

Channing-Cheetah's
He laughed like an irresponsible fœtus.
His laughter was submarine and profound
Like the old man of the sea's
Hidden under coral islands
Where worried bodies of drowned men drift down in the green
silence,
Dropping from fingers of surf.
I looked for the head of Mr. Apollinax rolling under a chair,
Or grinning over a screen
With seaweed in its hair.

I heard the beat of centaurs' hoofs over the hard turf
As his dry and passionate talk devoured the afternoon.
"He is a charming man"—"But after all what did he mean?"—
"His pointed ears ... he must be unbalanced,"—
"There was something he said that I might have challenged."
Of dowager Mrs. Phlaccus, and Professor and Mrs. Cheetah
I remember a slice of lemon, and a bitten macaroon.

THE BOSTON EVENING TRANSCRIPT



HE readers of the
*Boston Evening
Transcript*
The readers of
the *Boston
Evening
Transcript*
Sway in the wind
like a field of
ripe corn.

When evening
quickens faintly
in the street,
Wakening the
appetites of life
in some
And to others

bringing the *Boston Evening Transcript*,
I mount the stairs and ring the bell, turning
Wearily, as one would turn to nod good-bye to Rochefoucauld,
If the street were time and he at the end of the street,
And I say, "Cousin Harriet, here is the *Boston Evening Transcript*."

LA FIGLIA CHE PIANGE

O quam te memorem virgo...



TAND on the
highest pavement
of the stair—
Stand on the
highest pavement
of the stair—
Lean on a garden
urn—
Weave, weave
the sunlight in
your hair—
Clasp your
flowers to you
with a pained
surprise
Fling them to the
ground and turn
With a fugitive

resentment in your eyes:
But weave, weave the sunlight in your hair.

So I would have had him leave,
So I would have had her stand and grieve,
So he would have left
As the soul leaves the body torn and bruised,
As the mind deserts the body it has used.
I should find
Some way incomparably light and deft.
Some way we both should understand,
Simple and faithless as a smile and shake of the hand.

She turned away, but with the autumn weather
Compelled my imagination many days,
Many days and many hours:
Her hair over her arms and her arms full of flowers.
And I wonder how they should have been together!
I should have lost a gesture and a pose.
Sometimes these cogitations still amaze
The troubled midnight and the noon's repose.

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